

AC300 Master Course

Acupuncture Channels & Points I · VUIM · Dr. Vivian Zhang, Ph.D.

Print Edition

MODULE

1

Foundations

Channel Theory: History, Terminology & System Architecture

The conceptual scaffolding for the entire AC300 course

This Module Covers:

- History and origins of channel theory (Yellow Emperor's Inner Canon)
- Meridians vs. Collaterals — the core distinction
- Nomenclature: how every meridian gets its name
- Distribution rules on limbs, head, and trunk
- Circulation direction and the closed 12-meridian loop
- The Three Main Circuits (Anterior / Posterior / Middle)
- The three functions of the meridian system
- Ballroom & DanceSport relevance

Sourced from Lecture 1 (Dr. Zhang, 41 slides) and the Week 1 class transcript.

Two topics — cun measurement and meeting-point logic — are not in Lecture 1 and are flagged as pending in later modules rather than invented here.

How to Use This Module

This is the conceptual scaffolding for the entire course. Everything from the individual channels, points, and special-point categories built in Weeks 2 through 9 hangs on the handful of ideas in this module. If only one document gets re-read before boards in 2030, it should probably be this one – the channel-specific material is easier to relearn than the underlying logic that organizes it.

Scope note: cun measurement (the proportional point-location system) and meeting-point logic (Yuan-Source, Luo-Connecting, Five Shu, etc.) are NOT covered in Lecture 1. Rather than invent placeholder content, cun measurement is deferred to Module 2 (Lung/Large Intestine, where point-location language first appears) and meeting-point logic to the future Extraordinary Vessels / Special Points module.

Glossary

Read this before anything else – every term below is used without redefinition throughout the rest of this module.

Term	Definition
Qi	The animating functional activity/energy TCM holds moves through and sustains the body. One of the two substances the meridians transport, along with Blood.
Blood (Xue)	In TCM, a substance broader than the Western hematologic sense – it nourishes tissue and is co-transported with Qi through the channels.
Meridian (Jingmai)	Literally 'pathway.' One of the main trunk-line channels through which Qi and Blood circulate. Deep, few in number, vertical in orientation.
Collateral (Luomai)	Literally 'network.' A smaller branch off a meridian – shallow, numerous, running crosswise rather than in a straight vertical line. Meridians and collaterals together make up the channel system.
Channel	The umbrella term for the whole system – meridians and collaterals together. 'Meridian' means specifically the 12 primary trunk lines.
Zang	A Yin, solid organ in TCM organ theory (Lung, Heart, Spleen, Liver, Kidney, Pericardium). Each of the 12 primary meridians pairs with one Zang or Fu organ.
Fu	A Yang, hollow organ (Large Intestine, Stomach, Small Intestine, Bladder, Gallbladder, San Jiao).
San Jiao (SJ)	Also called Triple Burner/Triple Energizer – the Fu organ paired with the Pericardium channel. Standardized as 'SJ' throughout this course's weekly materials; used here for consistency even though Lecture 1's own slides mix 'SJ' and 'TE.'
Taiyin / Yangming / Shaoyin / Taiyang / Jueyin / Shaoyang	The six-part Yin/Yang naming system applied to each limb pair of meridians (three Yin, three Yang) – explained in full in Section 3.
The 12 Primary Meridians	The main trunk channels, one per Zang or Fu organ, forming six hand/foot pairs.
The 8 Extraordinary Meridians	A separate set of eight channels (Conception, Governing, and six others) that don't pair with organs the way the 12 primary meridians do – own module.
The 15 Collaterals	The named connecting branches off the primary meridians – covered in the Connective Tissue Systems module.
The 12 Sinew Meridians & 12 Cutaneous Regions	The muscular/myofascial and superficial-skin distributions paralleling the 12 primary meridians – the two categories most directly relevant to dance biomechanics.

1. A Quick History

- Acupuncture's core theory was first systematically recorded in The Yellow Emperor's Inner Canon (Huangdi Neijing), over 2,000 years ago.
- The Inner Canon marks the formal establishment of the Meridian System, built primarily around the 12 primary meridians, framed inside Yin-Yang cosmology – health as harmony between body and natural principles.

- The theory spread to East Asia by roughly the 6th century CE, and to Europe/North America from the 17th century onward.
- Today the WHO recognizes acupuncture as an evidence-based complementary therapy, integrated into healthcare systems worldwide.

Lecture 1 poses a genuine open question, worth sitting with rather than answering too quickly: which came first, the channels or the points? The lecture does not resolve it — it is presented as a live question in the field's own history, not a settled fact.

Where the theory came from — three converging strands

1. Observation of needling sensation — ancient practitioners noticing and tracking the sensation and conduction of stimulation (deqi/needle sensation).
2. Summary of acupoint effects, extended into lines — points were mapped for their effects first, and the lines connecting related points (channels) were inferred afterward.
3. Internal Qi flow observed through Qigong and guided-breathing practice ('small cycle' circulation) — a separate, meditative line of observation feeding the same theoretical structure.

The lecture quotes the Ling Shu directly on the physicality of the claim being made: ancient physicians held that a person's structure could be measured, palpated, and examined while alive, and dissected and observed after death — the channel system was proposed as something with a real anatomical correlate, even though (as the lecture notes) modern researchers still don't treat channels as fixed anatomical structures like nerves or vessels — more as functional networks integrating neural, circulatory, connective-tissue, and bioelectrical processes.

2. Meridians vs. Collaterals — The Core Distinction

	Meridians (Jingmai)	Collaterals (Luomai)
Meaning	Pathway	Network
Standing	Trunk	Branch
Distribution	Vertical line	Running crosswise
Depth	Deep	Shallow
Number	Few	Many
Function	Leading — the pathways through which Qi and Blood circulate	Supplement and bond — promotes Qi/Blood circulation

The lecture cites the Ling Shu directly here too: meridians run through the interior as the main trunk; the crosswise branches are collaterals; and branches off the collaterals are the finest sub-branches ('grandchild' vessels).

The river analogy, used explicitly in the Week 1 class discussion: meridians are the river itself; collaterals (Luo) are its tributary branches.

3. Naming the Meridians (Nomenclature)

Every one of the 12 primary meridians is named using three characteristics: (1) Hand or Foot — which limb it runs through; (2) Yin or Yang — and specifically which of the six Yin/Yang subdivisions; (3) A Zang or Fu organ — which internal organ it's paired with. Example given directly in the lecture: 'the Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin', 'the Stomach Meridian of Foot-Yangming.'

The Six Yin/Yang Subdivisions

- Three Yin: Taiyin, Shaoyin, Jueyin
- Three Yang: Yangming, Taiyang, Shaoyang

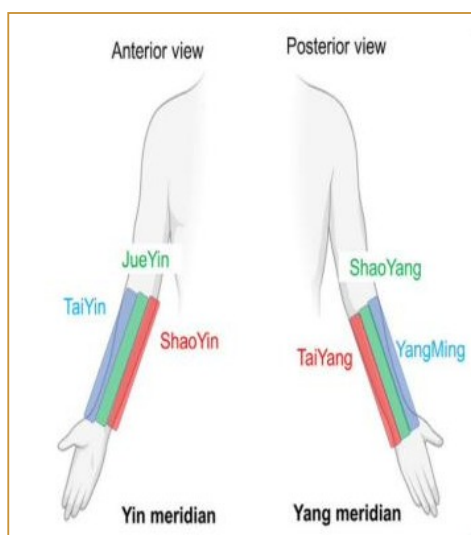
The Full Set of 12 Primary Meridians

	Yin Meridian (Zang)	Yang Meridian (Fu)
Six Meridians of Hand	Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin (LU)	Large Intestine Meridian of Hand-Yangming (LI)
	Heart Meridian of Hand-Shaoyin (HT)	Small Intestine Meridian of Hand-Taiyang (SI)
	Pericardium Meridian of Hand-Jueyin (PC)	San Jiao Meridian of Hand-Shaoyang (SJ)
Six Meridians of Foot	Spleen Meridian of Foot-Taiyin (SP)	Stomach Meridian of Foot-Yangming (ST)
	Kidney Meridian of Foot-Shaoyin (KI)	Bladder Meridian of Foot-Taiyang (BL)
	Liver Meridian of Foot-Jueyin (LR)	Gallbladder Meridian of Foot-Shaoyang (GB)

4. Distribution on the Body

On the limbs

- Medial (inner) aspect leads to Yin meridians.
- Lateral (outer) aspect leads to Yang meridians.
- Within each, front-to-back ordering: Anterior = Taiyin/Yangming; Posterior = Shaoyin/Taiyang; Middle = Jueyin/ShaoYang.



From Lecture 1, Slide 27 – forearm cross-section showing the six-part distribution: Taiyin/Jueyin/ShaoYin on the Yin (medial) side, Yangming/Taiyang/ShaoYang on the Yang (lateral) side.

Named exception (called out directly in the lecture): the Liver Meridian of Foot-Jueyin ascends to a point 8 cun above the medial malleolus, where it crosses and runs behind the Spleen Meridian of Foot-Taiyin – a specific, testable irregularity in an otherwise clean pattern.

On the head and trunk

- Anterior leads to Yangming.
- Posterior leads to Taiyang.
- Lateral leads to Shaoyang.
- Trunk (chest/abdomen) anterior specifically also carries Shaoyin, Taiyin, Jueyin.

Ballroom/Dance Relevance – medial/lateral injury pattern-matching (original synthesis, not lecture content)

The medial/lateral Yin/Yang split is worth knowing cold for injury pattern-matching. Medial-side overuse (adductor strain, medial knee pain common in turned-out Latin technique) sits on Yin-meridian territory; lateral-side overuse (IT band, lateral ankle sprains from a checked action) sits on Yang-meridian territory. Becomes directly useful once point selection for injury protocols comes up in the clinical module.

5. Circulation – Direction and Rules

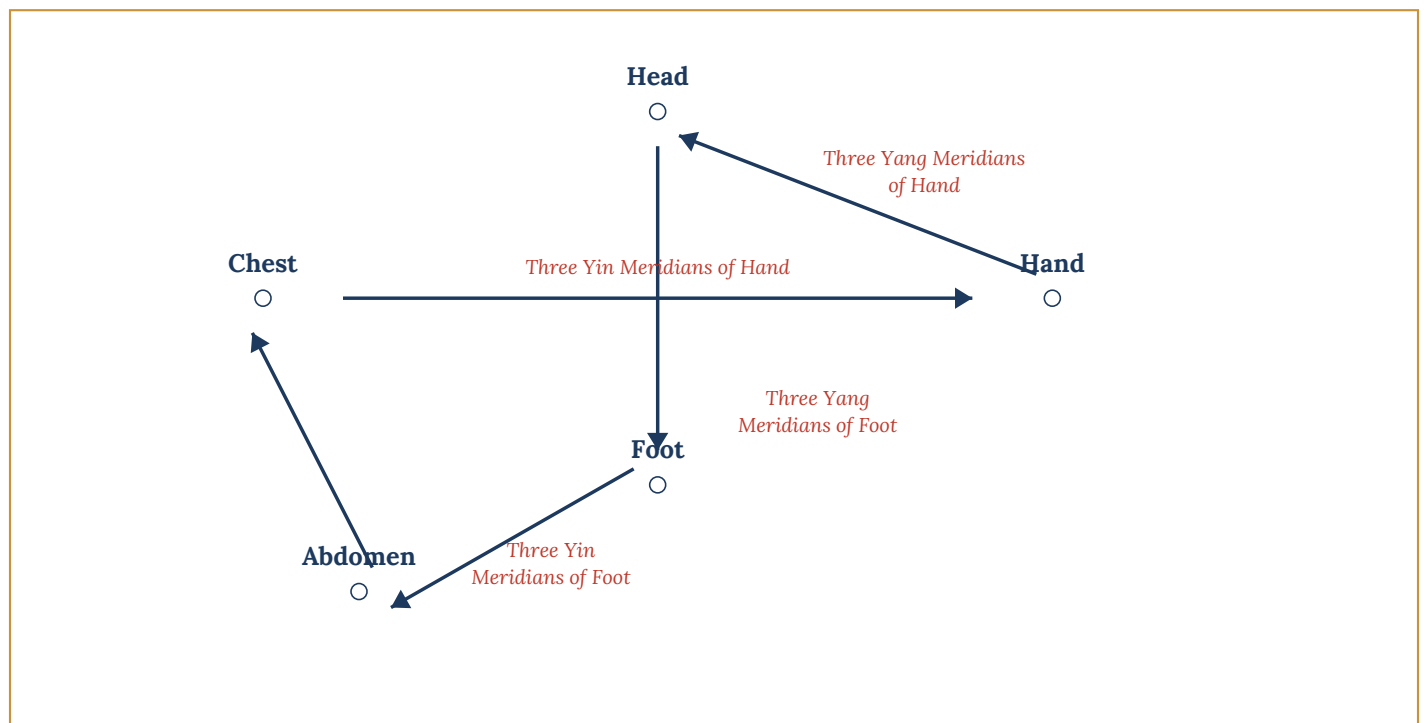
The four directional rules (stated as absolute rules, not tendencies)

1. Yin meridians of the hand: chest to hand.
2. Yang meridians of the hand: hand to head.
3. Yang meridians of the foot: head to foot.
4. Yin meridians of the foot: foot to abdomen.

The connection logic between them – worth actually drawing

1. The three Yin meridians of hand run chest to hand, converging at the fingertips with the three Yang meridians of hand (interior/exterior paired relationship).
2. The three Yang meridians of hand ascend fingertips to head, connecting there with the three Yang meridians of foot.
3. The three Yang meridians of foot descend head to toes, joining the three Yin meridians of foot.
4. The three Yin meridians of foot ascend toes to abdomen/chest, meeting the three Yin meridians of hand – closing the loop.

This closed loop is the entire logic of the meridian clock (Qi flowing through all 12 meridians across a 24-hour cycle) – not covered in depth in Lecture 1 beyond the instruction to notice, at any point in the day, which meridian's 'time' it currently is, as a memorization device.



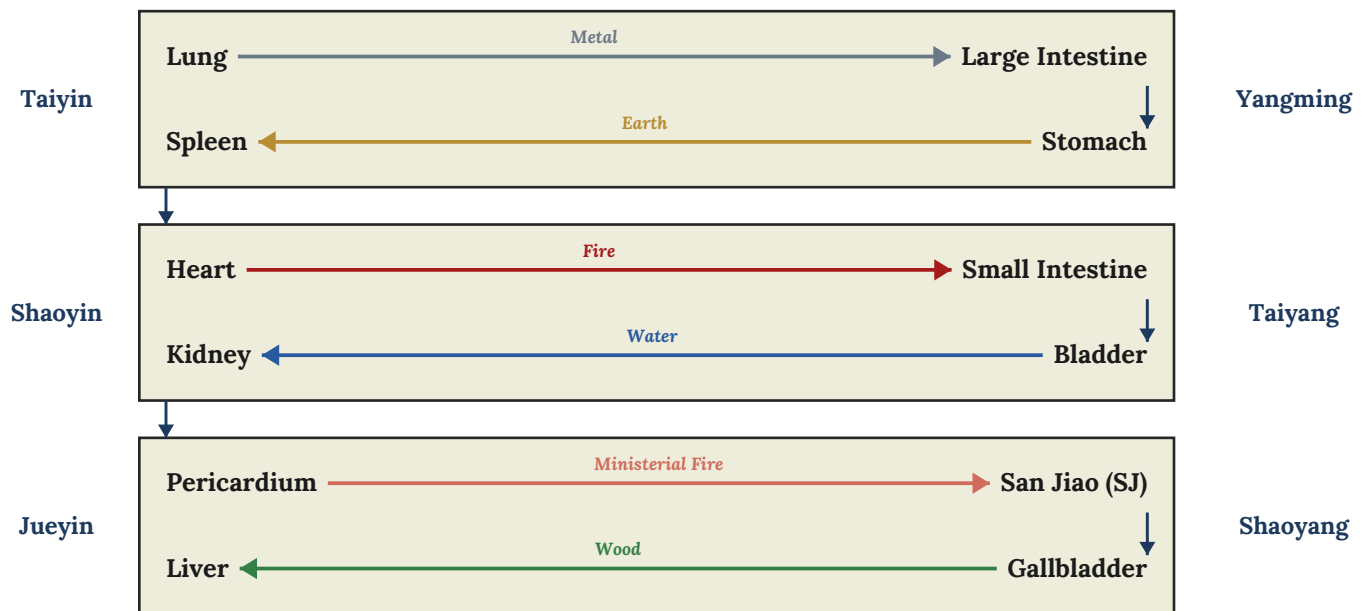
Redrawn from Lecture 1, Slide 29 ("Circulation of the Twelve Main Meridians") – the closed chest-hand-head-foot-abdomen loop described in Section 5.

6. The Three Main Circuits

This is the single most load-bearing organizational concept in the entire course — everything in Weeks 2 through 9 was taught circuit-by-circuit.

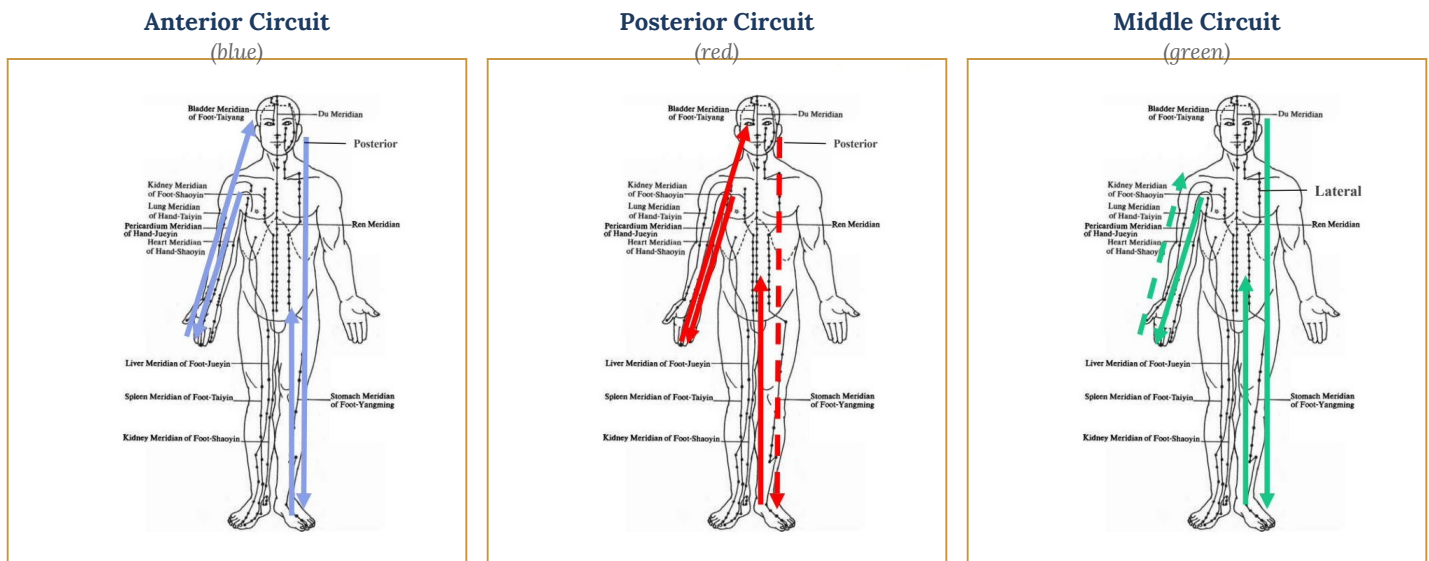
Terminology note (locked, per standing correction): Lecture 1 calls these the Anterior, Posterior, and Middle Circuits. A later lecture drops those labels in speech, so working materials should use 'Posterior Circuit (also called Inner Circuit)' to stay consistent with both namings, since Dr. Zhang is verbally inconsistent between them and exams may use either term. Anterior and Middle didn't pick up an alternate naming — only Posterior/Inner.

Circuit	Meridians	Yin/Yang labels
Anterior Circuit	Lung (LU) to Large Intestine (LI) to Stomach (ST) to Spleen (SP)	Taiyin / Yangming
Posterior Circuit (also called Inner Circuit)	Heart (HT) to Small Intestine (SI) to Bladder (BL) to Kidney (KI)	Shaoyin / Taiyang
Middle Circuit	Pericardium (PC) to San Jiao (SJ) to Gallbladder (GB) to Liver (LR)	Jueyin / Shaoyang



Chest > Hands/Fingers > Face/Head > Foot/Toes > Chest

Redrawn from Lecture 1, Slide 37 ("Three Main Circuits in the Flow of Qi"). Arrow colors follow the locked element color coding (Metal, Earth, Fire, Water, Ministerial Fire, Wood).



From Lecture 1, Slides 31/33/35 – the same base figure (meridian names labeled at left) with each circuit's own path traced in a different color. The abstract diagram above shows the logic; this shows where it actually runs on the body.

Correction from the earlier draft of this module: the three circuits are not three independent parallel loops. Lecture 1's own diagram shows small connecting arrows running from the bottom of each block into the top of the next – Spleen down into Heart, Kidney down into Pericardium, and Liver down, presumably closing back to Lung. That makes this one single continuous 12-organ cycle, in three consecutive segments, not three separate loops that each happen to share the same four-stage shape. Each segment still traces its own chest-to-hand-to-head-to-foot-to-chest pass (Section 5's logic applies within each segment), but the circuits hand off to each other in a fixed order – Anterior, then Posterior, then Middle, then back to Anterior – rather than running side by side. The diagram above is drawn to match this: the small arrows between panels are the handoffs, not a stylistic flourish.

Study method suggested directly by Dr. Zhang, worth taking literally

Draw all 12 meridians and their three circulations by hand, repeatedly, until the pattern is automatic. This isn't a throwaway suggestion – it's presented as the actual mechanism by which the material becomes memorable.

Ballroom/Dance Relevance – three functional lines (original synthesis, not lecture content)

The Three Circuits map loosely onto three functional lines already trained on the floor. The Anterior Circuit (LU-LI-ST-SP) runs the front body line – the anterior chain load in an American Smooth contra-body extension, or the front-of-hip/quad demand in a Rumba forward walk. The Posterior Circuit (HT-SI-BL-KI) tracks the posterior chain that holds frame and postural extension – erectors, glutes, hamstrings – the chain that fails first when frame collapses under fatigue in a long Standard round. The Middle Circuit (PC-SJ-GB-LR) runs the lateral/rotational line – hip rotation in Cha Cha, lateral stability in a Foxtrot sway. This is a mnemonic bridge, not a claim that the channels are these muscle chains.

7. What the Meridians Actually Do (Three Functions)

A. Transporting Qi and Blood, regulating Yin and Yang

Ling Shu, Ch. 47: the meridians and collaterals transport Blood and Qi to adjust Yin and Yang, nourish tendons and bones, and support joint function.

B. Resisting pathogens and reflecting symptoms/signs

Ling Shu, Ch. 71: when a pathogen involves the Lung or Heart, it lingers at both elbows; when it involves the Liver, both axillae; when it involves the Spleen, both groins; when it involves the Kidney, both popliteal fossae. A direct, specific clinical-pattern claim – worth citing precisely rather than paraphrasing loosely.

C. Transmitting needling sensation, regulating deficiency/excess

Ling Shu, Ch. 5 and Ch. 9: acupuncture's key task is regulating Yin and Yang, and treatment must aim at regulating the flow of Qi.

8. Ballroom & DanceSport Relevance – Summary

This section consolidates the sidebars above and adds context that spans the whole module. Everything here is original synthesis connecting channel theory to things already known from the floor and from teaching – not sourced from Dr. Zhang's lecture, and flagged as such throughout.

- The meridian clock, reframed practically: rather than 24-hour Qi-flow doctrine, it's a useful frame for when in a training day or competition schedule certain systems are more or less resilient – worth revisiting once TCM material on Qi/Blood depletion and fatigue comes up, directly relevant to back-to-back competitive rounds.
- This is exactly the terrain the capstone lit review lives in – the literature review on acupuncture for DanceSport injuries will eventually want a clean statement of channel distribution logic (Section 4) since injury-pattern-to-channel mapping is likely to be one of its organizing structures.

9. Still Open / Not Yet Sourced

- Cun measurement system – not addressed in Lecture 1. Will surface from Module 2 (Lung/Large Intestine) source material, where point locations are first given.
- Meeting-point logic (Yuan-Source, Luo-Connecting, Xi-Cleft, Five Shu, Eight Confluent, etc.) – not addressed in Lecture 1; built out as its own section in the future Extraordinary Vessels / Special Points module, using the existing Special Points Decoders as raw source material.
- SJ vs. TE labeling – Lecture 1 itself uses 'TE' on some slides and the paired-organ table elsewhere; later weekly materials standardized on 'SJ,' used throughout this module for consistency.

Source Notes

Primary source: 2026AC300Lec1Vivian.pdf (41 slides, Dr. Zhang, Week 1). Secondary source: AC300Week1.txt (class transcript) – used for the meridian/collateral river analogy, the direct student Q&A on 'channel vs. meridian' terminology (meridians = the 12 primary meridians specifically; channels = meridians plus collaterals, the whole system), and the 'draw it repeatedly' study instruction. Sections 1 through 7 are drawn directly from those two sources; Section 8 is flagged separately as original synthesis.